

*“Iran, for generations, was our neighbor. For 47 years under the Islamist regime, it was a threat. Now, it is our enemy.”*

**Abdulkhaleq Abdulla**, a political science professor from the United Arab Emirates



KATARINA PREMFORIS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

**Guests relax this week at a club in Dubai, a futuristic metropolis where more than 90 percent of residents are foreigners.**

DUBAI — Black smoke rose above Dubai’s international airport Saturday morning after an Iranian drone struck near a terminal. That night, a boom reverberated across the Marina neighborhood as debris from another drone slammed into a high-rise tower. By Sunday morning, the shrill blare of missile alerts rang out over mostly empty beach clubs.

More than a week after the United States and Israel attacked Iran, killing its supreme leader, Persian Gulf nations continue to be targeted by waves of Iranian drones and missiles that show few signs of letting up. The un-

## UAE, an oasis of stability, shaken by war

Iranian strikes force Gulf countries to take sides in a conflict they opposed

BY RACHEL CHASON

precedented assault has shaken countries that transformed in recent decades from sparsely populated desert nations into globally renowned business and tourism centers, calling into doubt their reputations as havens of wealth and stability and forcing them to take sides in a war they publicly opposed.

No place embodies the Gulf’s success — and the threats to it — more than Dubai, a futuristic metropolis that is the most populous city in the UAE and where more than 90 percent of its roughly 4 million residents are foreigners.

SEE UAE ON A10

## Nations open oil stockpiles in bid to steady prices

400 MILLION BARRELS FROM ENERGY AGENCY

Measures come as war in Iran rattles global economy

BY RACHEL CHASON, EVAN HALPER, SIHAM SHAMALAKH AND TARA COPP

DUBAI — The International Energy Agency on Wednesday announced that it would carry out its largest-ever release of oil reserves — 400 million barrels — in a bid to control spiking energy prices caused by the United States-Israel war against Iran, which shows no signs of slowing as it ends its 12th day.

The plan, aimed at stabilizing oil prices that have soared since the United States and Israel attacked Iran on Feb. 28, came as Iranian leaders declared they

were widening their assault on countries in the Persian Gulf, aiming to raise the economic price of the U.S.-Israeli military campaign to oust the government in Tehran.

About a third of global emergency stockpiles will be depleted once the IEA’s 32 members release the reserves — a decision that the organization’s executive director, Fatih Birol, said was made to address challenges in the oil market that are “unprecedented in scale.”

“Oil markets are global so the response to major disruptions needs to be global too,” Birol said in a statement. By early afternoon

SEE GULF ON A12

## Iranian school was on U.S. target list, possibly mistaken as a military site

*This article is by Tara Copp, Souad Mekhennet, Meg Kelly, Alex Horton and Susannah George*

The Iranian elementary school building where scores of children were killed as the U.S. and Israel began their massive aerial campaign was on a U.S. target list and may have been mistaken for a military site, multiple people familiar with the strike told The Washington Post.

The deadly attack occurred in the first few hours of the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran — just as parents were hurrying to the two-story schoolhouse to take their

kids home to safety — and killed at least 175 people, many of them children, according to Iranian state media.

It is still not clear why the building was hit, but one person familiar with the school strike said the building had been identified as a factory and had been an approved strike target. A second person familiar said there was an arms depot target located in the same area and did not know if the United States hit the school by mistake, or if U.S. officials had the wrong intelligence and thought the building was the arms depot.

SEE IRAN ON A13

**‘Unflattering’ images:** Pentagon bars Hegseth photographers. **A2**

**Ukraine talks:** Moscow says U.S. can’t be trusted after Iran. **A14**

## Baby left in cart in 1972 meets with women who found her

The reunion gives her clarity about her origin story and helps her feel more connected

BY SYDNEY PAGE

Rita Marshall had just unlocked her car when she noticed a shopping cart resting against the front fender. Inside was a brown paper bag — and it was moving.

“I didn’t know what to think,” Marshall said.

Marshall, then 20, had just seen an evening film with a friend and co-worker, Darlene Gilleland, 23, at Westgate Shopping Center in Fairview Park, Ohio. It was Aug. 20, 1972.

Marshall couldn’t make out what was inside the bag. She stepped closer and bent down.

“That’s when I saw the baby’s face,” Marshall said. “I was shocked.”

She called over Gilleland, who was equally stunned to see a newborn baby. The child was wearing a yellow onesie and was wrapped in a blue blanket.

“She was swaddled really tight,” Gilleland recalled.

“She was perfect, lying there as calm as can be,” Marshall said.

Marshall stayed with the baby while Gilleland sprinted back to the theater to call police. Within minutes, five patrol cars arrived. Officers peppered the women with questions, then they rode in the back of a patrol car to the hospital with the baby.

“She got examined there,” Gilleland said. “She was beauti-

ful and healthy.”

Doctors told them the baby was about two or three hours old when she was left in the shopping cart. Gilleland and Marshall both believed the baby’s mother had spotted them and thought they were a safe pair with whom to leave the child.

“I think we were being watched. They were looking for the right people,” Marshall said, noting that there were two apartment buildings behind the parking lot and that perhaps the mother was observing from there.

“It was just the right time and the right place,” Gilleland said.

From the hospital, the women went to a police station to file a report. The following day, they returned to the hospital to visit the baby, who was temporarily named Jeanne Westgate — Jeanne after one of the nurses who looked after her, and Westgate after the mall.

“We got to say goodbye,” Gilleland said, adding that they were told the baby would be taken to social services and eventually adopted.

They said they called the next day to find out what happened to the child but were given no information.

As the women moved through life, they never forgot about the baby girl, both said.

SEE OPTIMIST ON A2

## Federal panel drops plan to revisit covid vaccines

BY LENA H. SUN AND RACHEL ROUBEIN

A key federal vaccine advisory panel has abandoned an attack on the covid-19 mRNA vaccines — a shift that comes as some Republicans warn that any more changes to vaccine policy could damage the party in the midterms.

Some of Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.’s handpicked vaccine ad-

Kennedy advisers had considered stopping mRNA recommendations

visers had been seeking to potentially stop recommending mRNA shots. That plan is no longer moving forward, according to two people familiar with the matter

who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe internal deliberations.

In recent months, some members of the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices (ACIP) have publicly questioned the safety and manufacturing of the shots, including raising a debunked theory that DNA contaminants in the vaccines were harmful.

One option under consideration

was a potential vote to withdraw the federal recommendation for covid-19 mRNA vaccines altogether because of those objections, according to multiple people familiar with deliberations who spoke on the condition of anonymity due to the sensitivity of the matter. Such a change could throw into doubt how long insurers would continue to cover the shots free and whether pharmacies would

SEE RFK ON A5



EVGENIY MALOLETKA/AP

## Paralympics magic

Arna Albertsdottir of Iceland competes Wednesday in the cross-country 10-kilometer interval start sitting race at the 2026 Winter Paralympics in Tesero, Italy. Oksana Masters of the United States, the most decorated American Winter Paralympian, won the race for her third gold in four events. Wednesday’s feat allowed her to equal the three golds she won at the 2022 Beijing Winter Paralympic Games.

## IN THE NEWS

**Epstein documents** A bipartisan group of senators raised concerns in a letter to the GAO that the Justice Department failed to redact names and photos of victims. **A3**

**Jan. 6 display** Police say a plaque honoring officers was unlawfully installed in an area of the Capitol that’s not on public tours. **A4**

**THE NATION**  
**Republicans** in the House are struggling to craft a legislative agenda ahead of fall voting. **A3**  
**A former DOJ prosecutor** who proclaimed “this job sucks” will run for Congress. **A6**

**THE WORLD**  
**A drone assault** hit a major U.S. diplomatic facility and sprawling logistical hub in Iraq in a suspected retaliatory attack by pro-Tehran militias to the U.S.-Israel war on Iran. **A9**

**THE ECONOMY**  
**Inflation** rose in February at a 2.4 percent pace, giving households some reassurance, but the report does not capture the oil surge. **A18**  
**A Senate bill** would claw back pay and bonuses of CEOs deemed responsible for the collapse of a large bank. **A18**

**STYLE**  
**The Oscars** keep missing the moment on best actors, in which nominees can linger on the wait-list for years. **B1**

**SPORTS**  
**Remembering** that night 64 years ago when NBA Hall-of-Famer Wilt Chamberlain hit the century mark. **B7**

**THE REGION**  
**High levels** of bacteria have been found in a Montgomery County stream two months after a massive sewage spill in the Potomac River. **B13**

**LOCAL LIVING**  
**Interior designers** share the secret of using mathematics to bring harmony to the home.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A18  
COMICS.....B4  
OBITUARIES.....B15  
OPINION PAGES.....A15  
TELEVISION.....B6  
WORLD NEWS.....A8

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